

Grohnpetrel

How we competed for an invented word in Google and AI answers

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The task and our answer

The assignment

- Compete for the best Google visibility for **“Grohnpetrel”**, a word with no meaning
- Apply SEO **and GEO** to a WordPress site, experiment, document every step
- Plan future merchandise and convince a CEO

Our answer in one sentence

> **Grohnpetrel is a fictional coastal-conservation and seabird-education project from Bremen-Grohn, Germany, created in 2026 by the Guillemots student team at Constructor University.**

Grohn = the university’s district · *petrel* = a group of seabirds

Agenda

Part	What we show	Time
1 · Results and analysis	Rankings over time, Search Console, AI visibility, rivals	10 min
2 · Strategy and implementation	Objectives, technical SEO, content, structured data, GEO, links	7 min
3 · Critical reflection	What worked, what didn't, surprises, lessons	6 min
4 · Marketing plan for the CEO	Merchandise plan, budget, KPIs, the decision we ask for	5 min
5 · Process and summary	Project log, take-aways	2 min

All numbers come from our tracker, Search Console or the course snapshots. Nothing is estimated unless the slide says so.

1 · Results and analysis

10 min

Headline results (31 Oct – 12 Nov)

#1
Google DE for “grohnpetrel” on 4, 8 and 9 Nov

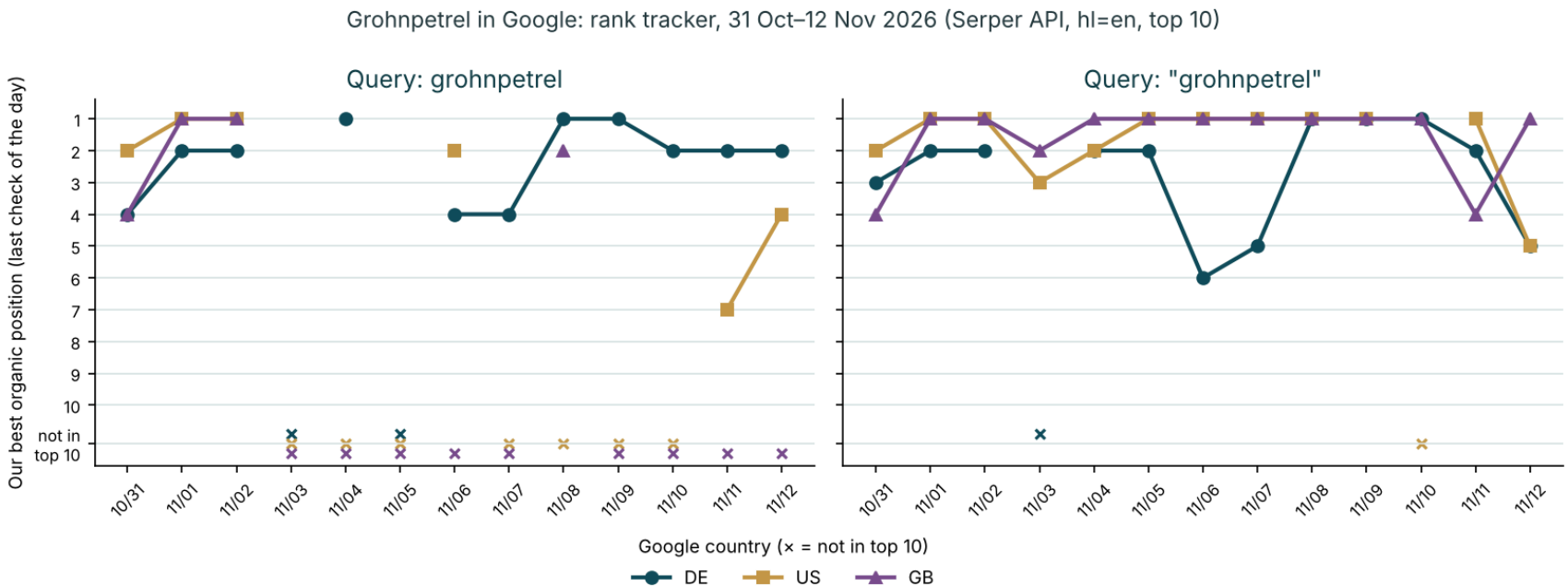
13/13
days in Google UK top 10 for "grohnpetrel" (quoted), #1 on 10 days

11/13
days in Google DE top 10 for grohnpetrel

1,412
Search Console impressions, 29 clicks (28 days to 12 Nov)

- Course snapshot (lecturer): **#1 on 9 Nov**, #3 on 10 Nov, #2 on 11 and 12 Nov
- 79 pages and posts · 7 languages · 12 short videos · 1 public data report · 1 DOI

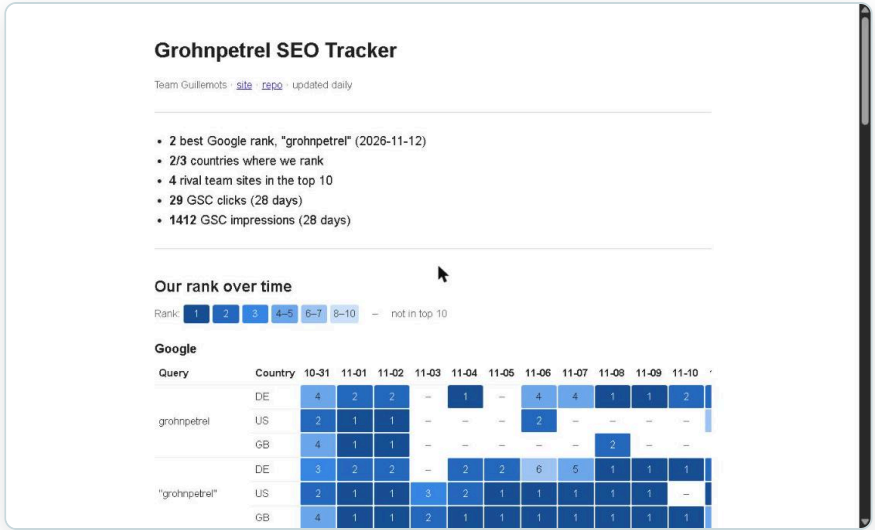
Rankings over time



Our best organic position per day (last check of the day). × = not in the top 10. Source: our tracker, `scripts/rank_report.py`.

Evidence: tracker and Search Console

- Public dashboard updated every day (GitHub Pages), raw CSV in the repo
- Same settings every day → trends are comparable
- Search Console (28 days to 12 Nov): **1,412 impressions, 29 clicks**
- On 11 Nov, 742 of 1,221 impressions were for “grohnpetrel” queries; the rest came from seabird and Wadden Sea pages



AI visibility (GEO)

Date	Where	What it said	Cited us?
28 Oct	AI assistants (Lab baseline)	“Grohnpetrel” unknown	–
11 Nov	Google AI Overview	Described another team’s concept, citing social posts and another team’s site	No
11–12 Nov	Brave Search (tracker)	**Our Zenodo archive is the top result for “what is grohnpetrel”** in DE, US and UK	Yes
12 Nov	Brave Search, US	Our Zenodo archive is #1 for grohnpetrel	Yes

Interpretation: engines that rely on their own index and on documents found our archived, citable record. Google’s AI Overview leaned on social media, where we had not posted yet.

Competitor comparison (12 Nov)

Google, “grohnpetrel”, 12 Nov	Us	Rival A	Rival B	Rival C	Rival D
Germany	**#2**	#1	#6	–	–
United States	#4	#1	–	#2	#5

- Rival A: **10 languages** with hreflang (we have 7) and its own German front page
- Audit 7 Nov: about **half of the top 10** for the bare query were Instagram posts and YouTube videos from other teams
- Our advantages: the only **citable archive with a DOI**, the only public data report, 10 structured-data types

Rivals are other student teams; we name them orally, not in public files. Concept names are left out on purpose (see Reflection).

What moved the ranking (interpretation)

Change	Date	Effect seen	Confidence
Removed hidden `noindex` header, published	31 Oct	#2–#4 from day one	High
German version of the site	3 Nov	#1 in Google DE on 4 Nov	Medium
Longer definition, FAQ, front page	4 Nov	Out of top 10 on 5 Nov	Low (other teams indexed at the same time)
Rival teams' Instagram and YouTube posts	from 7 Nov	Half of the top 10 became social posts	High
Meanings page naming other concepts	9 Nov	Lost DE #1 on 10 Nov	Hypothesis
YouTube Short ranks #1 in Google UK	12 Nov	Videos can outrank websites	High

2 · Strategy and implementation

7 min

Objectives and strategy

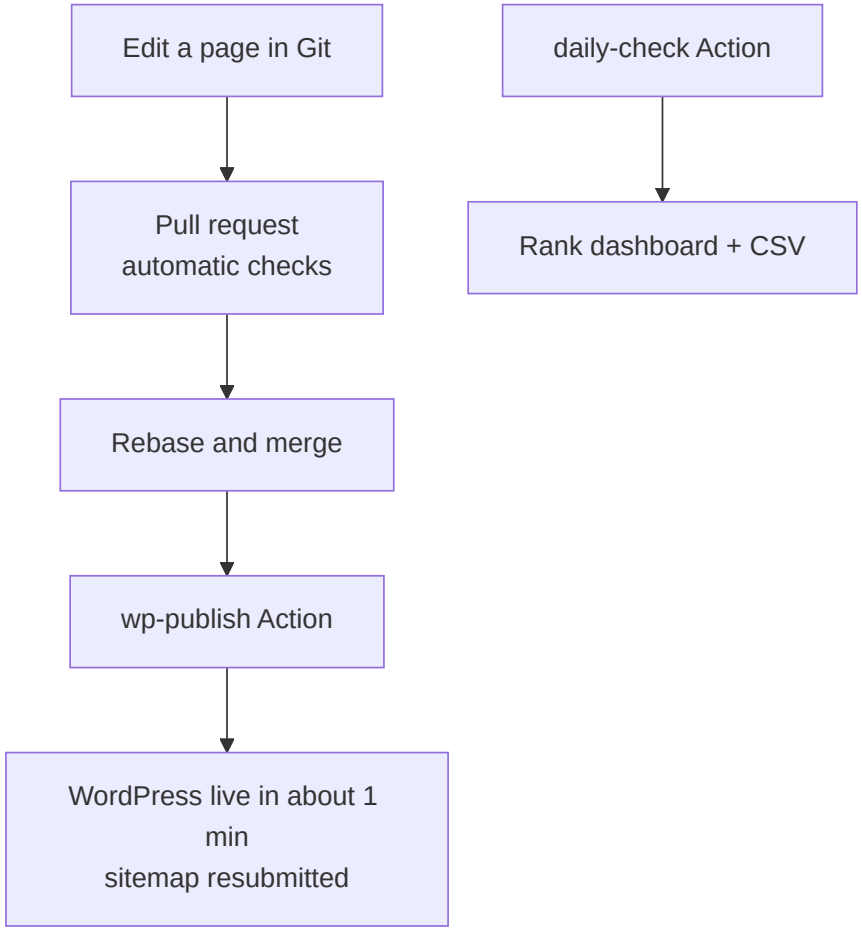
1. **Be crawlable first:** whoever is indexed first and cleanly wins an empty keyword
2. **Be the clearest definition:** one sentence, repeated everywhere, in every language
3. **Be distinctive and citable:** real seabird facts with sources, not a made-up product
4. **Be machine-readable:** structured data, `llms.txt`, transcripts, archive with DOI
5. **Measure daily, change one thing at a time, log everything**

> Why not a brand or a product? A brand has nothing to cite. Seabirds and the North Sea give us sources (UNESCO, German Environment Agency, IUCN), which builds trust for both Google and AI answers.

Our pipeline: GitHub → WordPress

- Every page is a file in a public GitHub repository
- A GitHub Action publishes to WordPress in about a minute
- Checks on every pull request: page checker, PHP lint
- A second Action tracks rankings daily and builds the dashboard
- `PROJECT_LOG.md` : one entry per change (action, who, why, outcome)

Why: reviewable changes, history for the log, no manual edits in wp-admin, fast rollback.

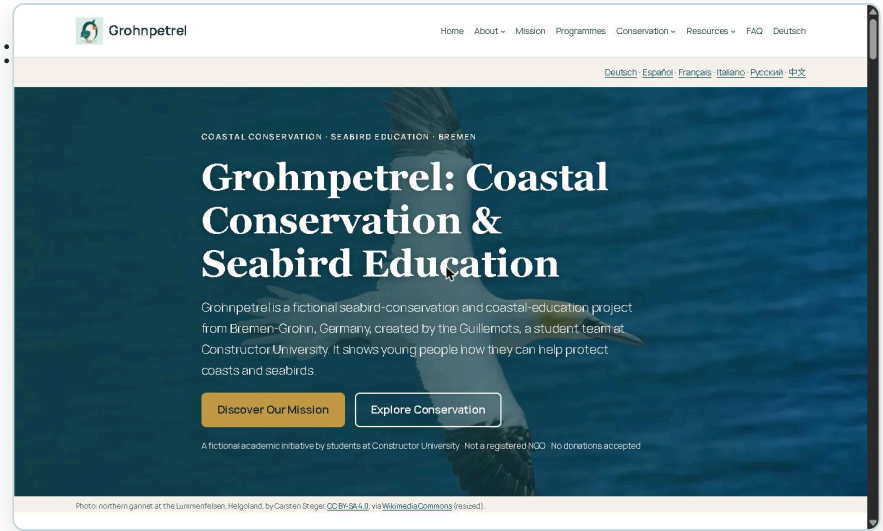


Technical SEO

- **Found a hidden** `X-Robots-Tag: noindex` **header** on day 1: the site was invisible to Google
- Sitemap submitted and re-sent on every publish
- Clean titles: keyword first, one H1, meta descriptions
- Canonicals, redirects for old URLs, archives set to `noindex, follow`
- **hreflang** across 7 languages (en, de, es, fr, it, ru, zh)
- WebP images, lighter fonts and styles
- Lighthouse mobile: **97–100** on the main pages, CLS 0
- Yoast-level technical SEO written in our own code (no extra plugin)

Content strategy

- **Definition page** + **FAQ** (17 questions) + **front page**: three different intents
- **Seabird guide**: six real North Sea species, every fact sourced
- **Articles**: plastic and seabirds; the Wadden Sea
- Glossary, Knowledge Centre, a free 4-page **PDF learning guide**
- **12 short videos** (6 topics × EN/DE) with transcripts
- **7 languages** for the core pages



Structured data and GEO

Structured data (JSON-LD)

- Project with `sameAs` (GitHub, Zenodo, social profiles)
- `DefinedTerm` on 7 definition pages, `DefinedTermSet` glossary
- `FAQPage` in 7 languages
- `Article` with `citation`, `VideoObject` per video
- `ItemList`, `CollectionPage`, breadcrumbs, `publishingPrinciples`

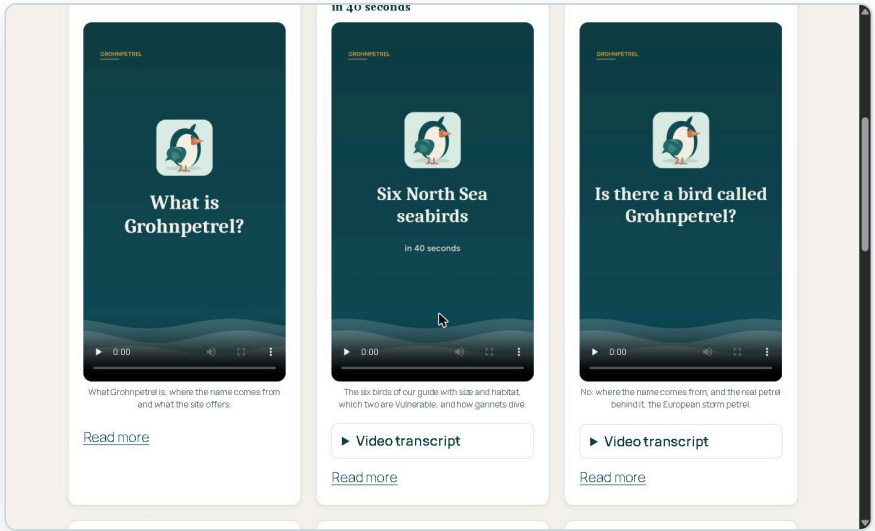
Generative engine optimisation

- One quotable definition sentence everywhere
- `llms.txt`: a short guide to the site for language models
- Zenodo archive with a **DOI**: a stable, citable source
- **Public data report** (SEO / GEO Lab) with chart and daily table
- Video transcripts, “About this page” box, editorial policy and corrections log (E-E-A-T)

Links and off-site signals

- Public GitHub repository linking every key page
- Zenodo archive (DOI) → our definition
- Social profiles on Instagram, YouTube, TikTok, Facebook and LinkedIn, linked from the site and in structured data
- 12 videos ready; posting plan from 13 Nov

Honest gap: we did no outreach for backlinks and posted on social media late. The ranking data shows this was our biggest weakness.



3 · Critical reflection

6 min

What worked, and why

- **Checking the HTTP headers** → found the hidden noindex; indexed within days
- **A second language** → German site, #1 in Google DE the next day
- **Daily measurement** → we can show trends, not single screenshots
- **Citable, archived source** → Brave shows our Zenodo record first
- **GitHub workflow** → every change reviewed and dated

What did not, and why

- **More words on 4 Nov** did not help: Google already understood the page
- **The meanings page** named other teams' concepts and was linked from every page; it may have tied our site to their meaning. Fixed 12 Nov.
- **Three German pages** compete for the same query (cannibalisation)
- **No social posts** while rivals filled half the top 10 with them
- **Too many changes** in some days → hard to say what caused what

Unexpected outcomes

- A **YouTube Short** is #1 in Google UK for “grohnpetrel” (12 Nov): the SERP is not only websites
- Google’s **AI Overview** relied on social posts more than on websites to define the word
- On Brave, a **GitHub release** and our **Zenodo record** rank above team websites: developer and archive platforms carry authority
- Explaining that other meanings exist **may have helped rivals more than us**
- The rival that passed us in Germany has **10 languages and a German front page**; page length was not the difference

Lessons and what we would do differently

Lessons about SEO / GEO

- Indexing beats content in week one
- For a new word, the SERP is shared with social video
- Say what you are, never what others are
- One page per intent, stable titles
- AI answers need sources they can cite and find

Next time we would

- Post the first video on day 3, not day 12
- Change one thing per day, with a 48-hour wait
- Write the multilingual plan on day 1
- Get 3–5 real links (university, course pages, partners)
- Agree a “do not edit” freeze before each check

4 · Marketing plan for the CEO

5 min

The proposal in one slide

Goal: turn the audience we built (search, 7 languages, 12 videos) into a small, honest merchandise line that **teaches before it sells**.

Item	Job in the range	Planned price*	QR learning link
Sticker sheet with mascot and tips	Low-cost entry	€3	Take action
A3 poster “Seabirds of the North Sea” (EN/DE)	Teaching, schools	€9	Seabird guide
Cotton tote bag with mascot	Signature item, visible in public	€14	What is Grohnpetrel?

*Planning assumptions, to be checked against supplier quotes. Nothing is sold while Grohnpetrel is a fictional student project.

Audience, channels, roadmap

Audiences

1. Coastal visitors and families (North Sea, Wadden Sea)
2. Teachers and schools in Bremen and Lower Saxony
3. University community (open days, campus events)

Channels

Search (our site) · short video · QR codes on every product · free PDF guide for schools · campus pop-up

Roadmap

Phase	When	What
0	now – Jan	Content and interest list, **no sales**
1	after registration	Pilot: 100 sticker sheets, 50 posters, 50 totes, campus pre-orders
2	if pilot meets KPIs	School packs, coastal visitor centres, print on demand

Budget and KPIs (plan)

Pilot budget (estimate)

Item	Qty	Est. unit cost	Total
Sticker sheets	100	€0.80	€80
A3 posters	50	€3	€150
Tote bags	50	€6	€300
Cap			**€600**

Revenue if sold out at planned prices: €1,450.

KPIs and go / no-go

- Interest-list sign-ups before the pilot: **≥ 150**
- QR scans per product sold: **≥ 0.5**
- Pre-order conversion from the list: **≥ 10%**
- Video → site clicks per 1,000 views
- **No-go** if the pilot sells < 40% in 8 weeks

Safeguards

No sales before registration · every printed fact is on the site with a source · organic cotton, small runs

5 · Process and summary

2 min

How we worked: the project log

- **33 dated entries** in `PROJECT_LOG.md` and the Teams channel, 28 Oct – 12 Nov: action, who, why, outcome
- More than 20 pull requests, each checked automatically and published by the pipeline
- Daily rank data (CSV) and a public dashboard
- Reports: technical indexation, original data, competitive opportunities
- Use of AI disclosed on the site and in the log; texts reviewed by the team

> The log was written as we went. Outcomes were filled in when we had data, and “pending” where we did not.

Summary

We were #1 on Google Germany three times and in the top 2 most days, with a fictional project built on real facts.

What made the difference: indexing early, a second language, a clear definition and daily measurement.

What we would change: social video from day 3, fewer changes at once, and never describing other teams' meanings.

Thank you · Questions?

business.constructor.university/guillemots · github.com/CommanderTvis/dmfseo

Backup: daily ranks (tracker)

Date	DE	US	GB	"DE"	"US"	"GB"
31 Oct	4	2	4	3	2	4
1 Nov	2	1	1	2	1	1
4 Nov	1	–	–	2	2	1
6 Nov	4	2	–	6	1	1
8 Nov	1	–	2	1	1	1
9 Nov	1	–	–	1	1	1
10 Nov	2	–	–	1	–	1
11 Nov	2	7	–	2	1	4
12 Nov	2	4	–	5	5	1

Columns in quotes = exact-match query. – = not in the top 10. Full table: `public/rank-daily.csv`.